

64 SQUARES FIND ANOTHER ESPORTS ARENA

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The Esports World Cup (EWC) Foundation broke a glass ceiling when it included chess as one of its titles at the EWC 2025. World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen (in classical chess) won the tournament, and lakhs of viewers logged in to see global stars of the sport fight it out for the title.

Chess has now been included in the inaugural Esports Nations Cup. It became one of the eight titles announced for the tournament, alongside Mobile Legends: Bang Bang, Trackmania, Dota 2, Fatal Fury: City of the Wolves, Honor of Kings, Counter Strike 2 and EA FC.

Unlike the World Cup, where clubs and individuals compete, the Nations Cup will operate in a country-versus-country dynamic, and will feature a prize pool of \$20m (approximately Rs. 181 crore).

SCHEDULE AND FORMAT

The tournament will take place between November 2 and 8, 2026, in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, in a Rapid 10+0 time control format.

Sixty-four players from as many nations will be directly invited based on the official Champions Chess Tour (CCT) rankings, 56 will qualify through regional qualifiers, and eight will come in as wildcard entries.

Qualifying slots for each region: North America (8), South America (8), Africa (8), Western Europe (8), Eastern Europe (8), Middle East, India and Central Asia (8), East Asia, Southeast Asia and Oceania (8).

The players will be divided into 16 groups of eight players each, with each player competing in a

round-robin group stage. The top four players from each group will advance to the next stage for single-elimination playoffs. All matches will be played as best-of-two contests.

From the quarterfinals, the teams will play best-of-four matches. Armageddon games will be used as tie-breakers.

AN ATTEMPT TO TAP THE INDIAN MARKET

Popularity of chess has increased exponentially in India after the recent success of D. Gukesh, who became the youngest world champion, and the Indian teams – open and women — who won gold at the Chess Olympiad 2024.

The EWC Foundation, naturally, sees promise in such a growing fanbase.

"Last year we had our first Indian club (S8UL) and what was clear to us was that with the inclusion of chess, the passion of Indian gaming fans was nothing like we had ever seen before," Mike McCabe, Deputy Chief Executive Officer (CEO) and Chief Operating Officer (COO), EWC, told *Sportstar* in a select media interaction.

"We are looking at what we can do more from India's perspective. It has a positive future. We want to see more rosters go through the qualifications, as we are excited to see participation from more Indian clubs."

Two Indians participated in the Esports World Cup 2025 — Nihal Sarin (S8UL Esports) and Arjun Erigaisi (Gen. G Esports, [in pic](#)), with the former reaching the quarterfinals and the latter finishing fourth.